

time a shirt stitched at Tardeo's Kachins touched my skin, the affection that overwhelmed me as I wiped the drool off my exhausted dog Junior's mouth, the twist in my gut as I packed the first canvas bought by the Tata Group…" The pages are also peppered with QR codes, which direct the reader to relevant posters, photos, films and audio-visual recordings—an innovative touch.

Before Palekar became the actor and auteur we know and admire, he was a painter. He showed early promise, enrolling in art classes while in school. Growing up in Bombay's Shivaji Park, walking to Dadar Station was a daily affair. "On the way, there were studios making hoardings, done by hand, with the faces magnified almost 20 times. Invariably, I would stop there and linger. I think somewhere it seeped into me," he recalls. Once it came time to select a stream for college, he joined the Sir J.J. School of Art. Barring a phase when he paused, he has continued to paint. "When I turned 70, I went back. It's like completing a circle.... For the last few years, I have been a full-time painter and part-time actor!" he says.

VIEWFINDER
A Memoir
by Amol Palekar
WESTLAND
320 pages;
₹**999**

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For someone who was catapulted into the national imagination with 'regular guy' roles in hits like *Rajnigandha* (1974), *Gharaonda* (1977), *Baton Baton Mein* (1979) and *Gol Maal* (1979), acting happened only through a chance meeting with theatre director Satyadev Dubey. Possibly, Palekar's greatest contribution has been to turn the conventional idea of masculinity on its head. "Why is masculinity only rough and tough?" he asks. "Why can't it be loving, affectionate, fumbling? All that is part of being a man too."

As an actor, Palekar has explored manhood in a nuanced manner. "To give you an example, in my first Hindi film, *Rajnigandha*, there is not a single moment where the man I play says 'I love you', and yet he manages to convey all his love." While the script was the starting point, Palekar managed to build on it. "My only concern was that...it shouldn't look like he is indifferent to the relationship. As an actor, I tried to bring out the warmth and love in my expressions."

Craving more creative control, Palekar turned to direction with the Marathi film *Akriet* (1981), based on the occult killings that occurred in Maharasthra's Manwath in the early '70s. Since then, he has charted a course all his own in cinema, never bowing to fashion or convention. Indeed, he dedicates *Viewfinder* "to those who believe in the power of resistance".

Looking back at the past 80 years, Palekar says, "It is unbelievable that I could do so many things, dabble in so many fields simultaneously." But for the multi-hyphenate Palekar, the arrow of time only points forward. He has a favourite story about the Zen master who carried a beautiful woman across the river. Once they had crossed, the Zen master left her there, physically, of course, but mentally as well, something his acolyte, who kept berating him, was unable to do. "You don't hold on to anything…you just keep going," says Palekar. *Viewfinder* may well be his greatest act of catharsis. ■

–Amit Dixit

of us. A section on icons is written by unapologetic fans of actors like Dharmendra, Sanjeev Kumar, Rakhee, Rajesh Khanna. Legends like Anand Bakshi, L-P, Amol Palekar, Shyam Benegal, as well as several 'little stars' like Anil Dhawan, Navin Nischol, or Vidya Sinha, are covered. As is the in-danger-of-being-forgotten Manoj Kumar. There are omnibus articles like the one on Gulzar which entirely abandons the book title to give us a satisfying long biography of all of Gulzar's oeuvre. There are also a few highly focused, very enjoyable articles like the one which unpacks the political aspect of RD's music via one song—'Lekar Hum Deewana Dil'—or the one that discusses his early 1970s music. Equally enjoyable are essays that discuss opening-credits sequences; the 'first day first show' phenomenon; listening to dialogues on cassettes; Salim-Javed's 'Vijay' vs Vijay Tendulkar's work; and the unique *Shalimar*. There is, remarkably, no dedicated article for Bachchan who is inevitably mentioned in many of the write-ups. But there are pleasant surprises like the one on the Kader Khan-Prayag Raj-K.K. Shukla triumvirate who gave Bachchan more hit movies than Salim-Javed.

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The decade, described by Varun Grover as "post-golden but pre-rotten… still full of joy and insights" is looked at through many interesting themes as well: How Nari Hira's *Stardust* brought in a wickedly gossipy culture of film journalism; how the roles of the heroine and vamp evolved; how villains changed from being enemies of individuals to enemies of the nation; the costumes and styling of the decade; the lyricists; 'parallel' cinema; or the pioneering 'filmosophers'—Mani Kaul and Kumar Shahani.

A book like this is not just enjoyable but also a pointer to what a great resource our memories and anecdotal references can be; a kind of 'little history' authored by the individuals who grew up with the nation even as it grew with them, and their response to something like movies—so often the bread and butter of our cultural/psychic lives. I look forward to the editors' next omnibus with articles on Joginder, Ramsay Brothers, Shetty, Mangesh Desai, cabaret sequences, Nagin, and the aloo patties we got in the intervals! However, as Sriram Raghavan says in his delightful memoir: "Please check your longings before leaving the cinema." ■

–Juhi Saklani